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Hollerbeier Haven

Journal of Traditional Deitsch Wisdom

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Die Volkstimme



Wisdom shows the way for all who seek her out

+ + +

Her path is easy to find, but hard to follow home



The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts is recording stories, interviews, memories, and knowledge of the healing traditions of Pow-wow or Braucherei. We are creating an archive of this tradition in order to preserve our heritage and ensure the practice. If you know anyone who practices or has a story to tell, we'd love to hear from you; whether you'd like to give a personal interview or prefer to remain anonymous, simply write to us. Your personal experiences are culturally valuable and will be treated with the utmost respect. You can contact us with questions or information by writing to:

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Merry Christmas! Happy New Year!
Hallich Yuul!

To many this New Year represents a fresh start after a terribly difficult and trying year. Across our nation far too many families have lost jobs and homes, and for too many this is not a very merry Christmas. With this Holiday season I would encourage those of you who have gotten by this year (or even done well) to be generous with charities, and maybe even donate some time to a charity if you can.

For Three Sisters this has been a very difficult year. We have seen a drop in our membership and have seen far fewer than normal faces at our events throughout the year. But our goose is not cooked! Instead of throwing in the towel we are exploring other options. I hope that this year Three Sisters will be able to transform into a non-profit educational organization. Our goal is to develop funding that is not dependent on the fees we charge for events, so that our events can eventually be free or almost free... affordable to all!

The mission of Three Sisters has always been to share the knowledge we have accumulated with the heirs of the Pa Deitsch culture. With this New Year we are simply taking hibernation seriously, and hoping to come out from our chrysalis in the spring with new wings!

Hope this season finds you and yours warm, fed, and healthy!

+++ Jesse Tobin, Editor +++

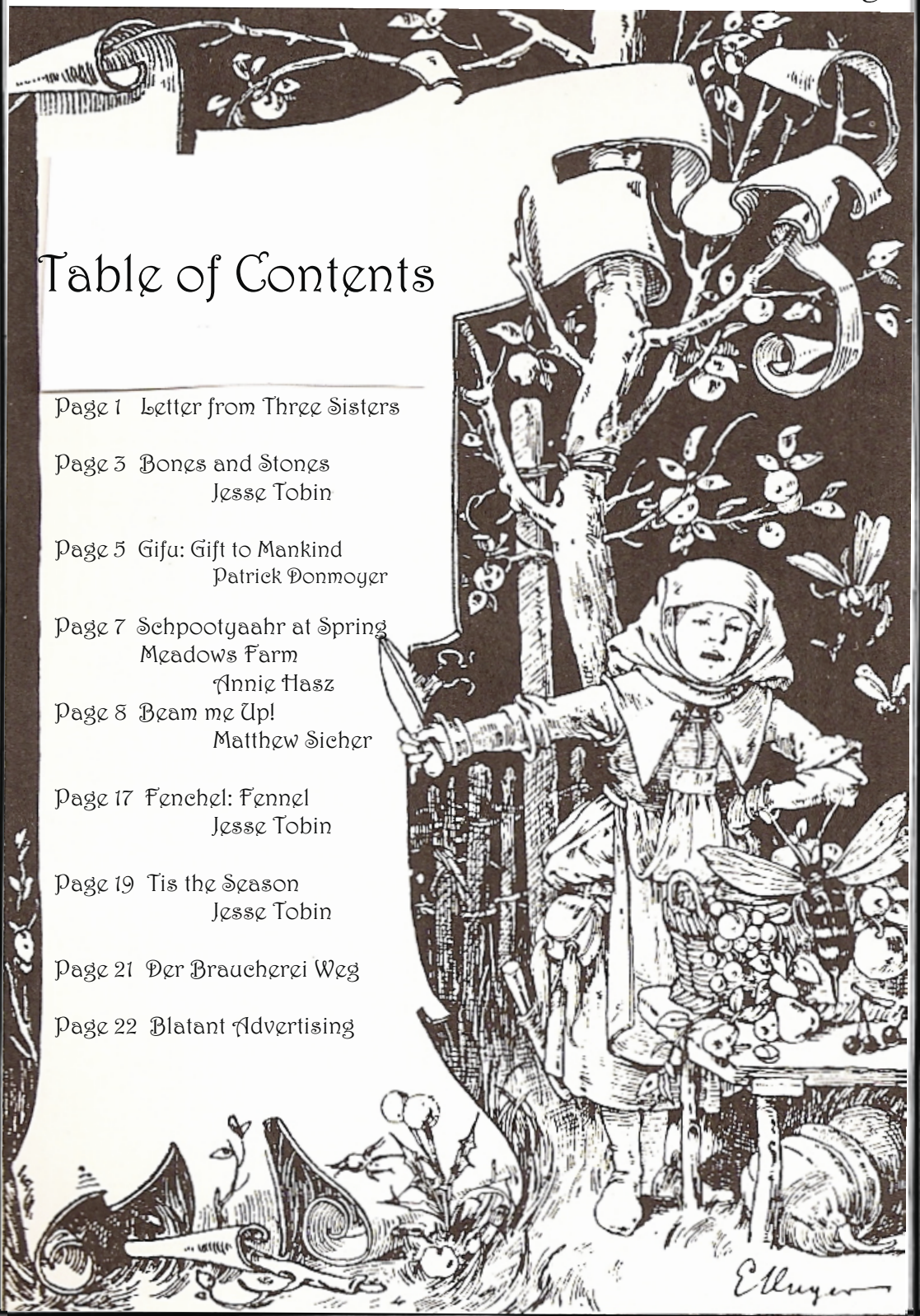


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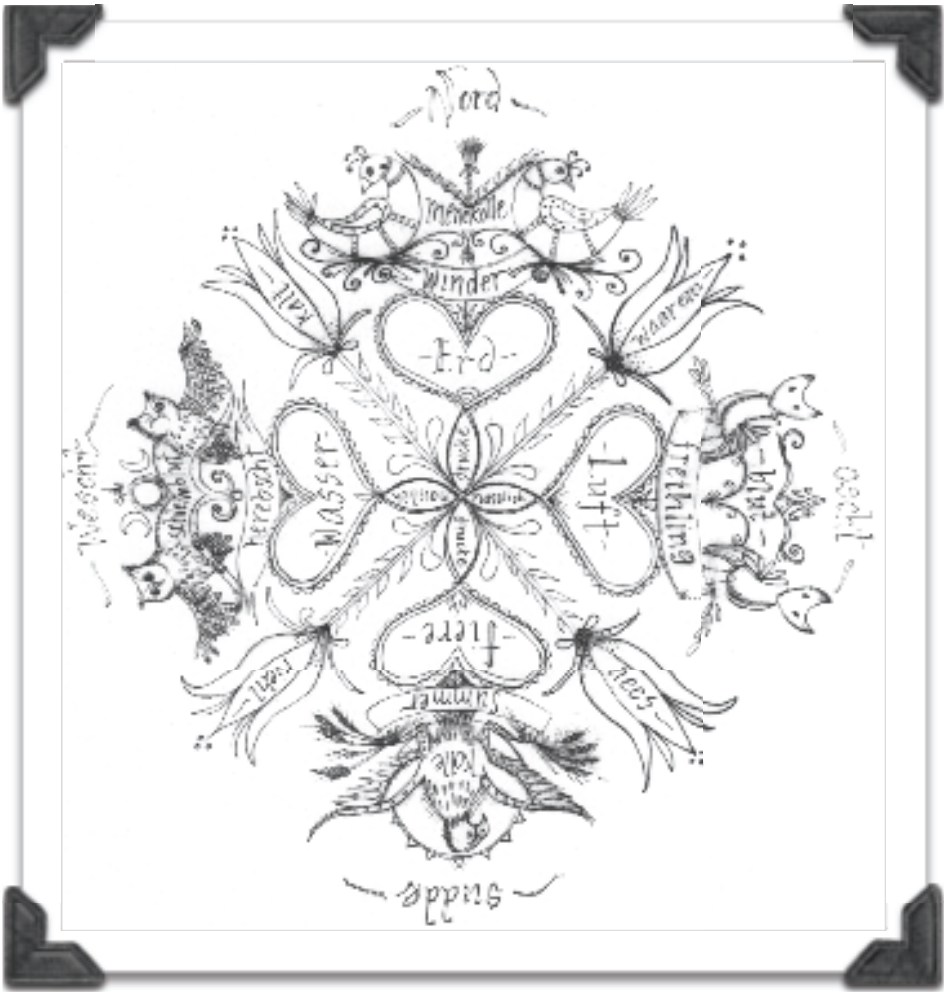
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Bones and Stones

By Jesse Tobin



Pictured above is a fraktur rendering of the Medizinraad (medicine wheel) of the Oley Freindschaft. Original artwork by Susan Hess reprinted here with permission.

Earth is the element with the longest memory. In traditional medicine it represents the melancholic humor, which is also called black bile. An excess of black bile (which earth astrological sign natives are particularly prone to) can cause a person to become so entrenched in memory and the events of their past that they become cynical, critical, hopeless, depressed. In short: melancholy sets in. The Greeks saw this as an actual substance that slowed the emotions, the mind, and the body, bringing the individual to a spiritual stagnancy. Modern herbalists would call this “stagnant depression”.

This holding ability of the earth element is not all bad, however. As everything in the energetic world, it is only a negative when it is out of balance and causing

"dis-ease". The pure energetic nature of the earth element acts as a battery: retaining information, imagery, and energy long after it is drained from the air and water that surrounds us. Earth provides structure through which energy can flow in a much more directed and controlled way. It provides a container for the other elements. This is easy to see even in the way we apply the use of minerals in the mundane world: we use minerals in the creation of batteries themselves, or in the making of a wood stove or cast iron radiator. These items hold electricity or heat for hours after the original source is extinguished. We can see the memory of minerals in our own bodies: our teeth and bones reflect the history of our health. Archeologists can tell the story of a person's life hundreds and thousands of years after their death simply by examining the skeleton they leave behind. Our bones, hair, and nails remain the longest behind us, as though they wish to tell the story of life over and over again.

In the energetic world of Braucherei there are many ways in which stones and minerals are used. One very basic example is what we call *Glee Schtee* (or "little stones"). Braucherei, unlike many more "new age" healing practices, does not put a huge amount of importance on the type of mineral used in the case of Glee Schtee.

Many healing practitioners who use gemstones in their practice are particularly focused on the properties of an individual type of stone. Glee Schtee, in contrast, are stones that a practitioner is collects anywhere that they find them. If a Braucher is walking on the beach or in the woods, or on the road, and a small stone "calls out" to them or catches their eye, they are to collect it. These stones are kept and infused with personal power in some way. Some practitioners pray over the stones or hold them with a strong intention. Others simply put them beneath their pillows to "charge" them. After they are charged they are kept in a sacred and safe place for the Braucher to draw upon when they are needed.

The charged stones can then be carried by the Braucher to hold his or her energy, to help them remain solid or rooted and strong in a difficult circumstance, or in unfamiliar or unfriendly territory. These could be carried into court, into a session with a challenging client, or when traveling or engaging in dangerous work. When they are used for clients, these charged stones can be used as the power source at the center of an amulet. In this case it would likely be surrounded by prayers and herbs and bound in white cloth with a red string.

In some cases these stones are not charged, but are cleansed instead, and kept "empty" so that they can act as a drawing agent in a powwow cure. In this case, a Braucher would pass his or her hands over a person while in a certain prayerful state of mind and chanting particular prayers. The Braucher essentially douses over the person in search of an excess or out of balance energy in the the body. If this is found, an empty stone could be used to draw out the energy and take it away. This stone would then be returned to the earth in some way. This drawing stone acts in much the same way as the common potato wart cure does, with the potato drawing out the wart and returning it to the earth. Here we see another simple, but important aspect of the earth element: the earth itself is the great recycler. The earth is capable of transforming disease and rot into health and life. It is for this reason that most disease is returned to the earth during energy work.

Among the interviews given to me by my mentor, Dennis Boyer, there was one man in particular that explained the use of four element stones given to him by

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Gifu - Gift to Mankind

by Patrick Donmoyer

"Generosity brings credit and honour,
which support one's dignity;
it furnishes help and subsistence
to all broken men who are devoid of
aught else."
-Anglo-Saxon Rune Poem, Northvegr Foundation

The seventh rune is called Gifu, translated from the Anglo-Saxon language as "gift" or "generosity." The rune's appearance is like that of the Latin letter X, with two equal staves crossed at the middle, overlapping to form a diagonal cross which is a vertically and horizontally symmetrical figure. It is because of this form, that Gifu is a symbol of partnership, and a bringing together of two separate members into conjunction. A gift in this case means not merely a token of generosity, but the inevitable result of partnership. It is as true today as it was in the ancient world that a gift is often a symbolic gesture which establishes a bond.

A gift is a physical manifestation of the human need for connection with others, whether it is a work relation, a friend, or a lover. The latter are usually the most common interpretation. As the rune poem suggests, a gift can serve to sustain and empower a relationship, both by aiding another and in so doing, cultivating an appreciation for the act of providing. As with the nature of many of the runes, it refers to a cyclical process, not a linear progression. The numeralogical association with seven as a sacred number is also important to this understanding. In most cultures of the world, seven was the number of the planets visible to the naked eye. It was believed that these seven heavenly bodies worked in harmony to influence the patterns of earthly affairs. This is why the number of days in a week are seven in many cultures. Seven is universally a number of cosmic balance.

Gifu is one of the oldest forms used by human beings for decoration, protection, and spirituality. Some of the earliest known markings created by humankind are diagonal overlapping lines, carved into bones and painted on walls. The diagonal cross is visually similar to the vertical cross in some respects, but the meanings are different because of orientation. A vertical line crossed by a horizontal line suggests on a very basic level some measure of spatiality, a conjunction between lateral movement and upward movement. A diagonal cross however, references a specific location and mimics the crossing of human arms over the upper body, a gesture of protection, a gesture of an embrace, and a gesture of closure. It is for these reasons that the form of X is often used as a protective glyph in many cultures. The X is extremely common in folk applications of

architecture and graffiti. In Pennsylvania German folklore, three crosses are frequently used interchangeably in protective circumstances with the three upright crosses of the Three Kings or the Holy Trinity.

In divination, Gifu is often thought to symbolize the feminine qualities of love, sexuality, the earth, and procreation. It is for this reason that the rune is often associated with the goddess archetype as the goddess is both the giver and sustainer of life. When Gifu is cast in divination, it can represent a relationship in the querent's life, or the possibility of a future connection. Gifu is one of several runes which cannot be reversed. The rune appears the same no matter which way it is turned. This reflects the nature of the meaning of this particular idea as exclusively beneficial. It does not portend however, that every relationship in question is harmonious.

Each rune's meaning is inherently connected to other runes involved in the casting, and although Gifu does refer to a relationship, which is a positive concept, it can also suggest the presence of a relationship for the querent, rather than the state of a relationship. If Gifu is cast in conjunction with an upright Feoh for instance, the outcome can be thought to tend towards the benign, as both are positive runes, dealing with sustaining power and fertility. However, if Gifu is cast in conjunction with an inverted Feoh, the outcome would be the opposite, tending towards a reading of loss of material sustenance or creative power.



In previous articles, divinatory procedure was briefly introduced using the single rune casting, and the three rune casting, for past-present-future. Another method similar to the three rune method is the five rune casting. This system builds upon a the casting of three runes for past, present, and future, with the additions of two new positions, one which explains the nature of possible assistance to create change, and another which relates to factors that must be understood and accepted. In this sense, the two relate to opposite poles of experience: potential change and potential stability. This method can be formed by laying five runes face-down, forming a vertical cross,

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Schpootyaahr at Spring Meadows Farm

by Annie Hasz

The season in Mosherville ended in a fury of root digging and plowing. With an almost constant accompaniment of the screaming of broad-winged hawks as they gathered up for southern migration, we put the garden to bed and worked up ground for next season. On a seductively warm day in mid-October, I harvested the last bushels of purple, red, orange, and yellow carrots along with the beets and parsnips. I packed them in feed sacks with moist dirt and sand for winter storage in a cold cellar. This sweet bucolic day was a sharp contrast to the final market day when I'd woken to inches of snow. I had to sweep off the broccoli to see where to cut and brush off the row cover that hid the lettuce and spinach from the snow's bite.

Fall came with a reminder that I was just beginning to learn the intricacies of ox-driving. After a morning of successful plowing, I went back out to catch Burt and he shook his head at me, kicking at his stomach with a back hoof as though he had been bitten. I stepped back fearfully and he proceeded to threaten more aggressively with his horns and stamp, just like a bull, before running full speed to the other end of the pasture. In these few moments I quickly trained him to be aggressive and the rest of the day he responded to commands with threat behavior, having associated it with gaining freedom. In the coming weeks, I struggled to drive them straight as we plowed the longest furrows yet in a ½ acre plot that will be planted in oats in springtime.

One morning I found a note on the table from Andy telling me that I had reached a wall in my work with animals. Instead of relaxing and observing when the situation became out of my control, I fought for control or responded with fear. Allowing my base predatory instincts to determine my next actions cast the oxen in the prey role. This is the "original sin" of the Bible, according to Andy, for an agrarian who allows primal predatory instincts to dominate interactions with her animals destroys the husbanding relationship that is the foundation of her subsistence. The control I fought for was an illusion. Never can you control another. The frustration I felt was unnecessary. Never is the animal "wrong" because it acts perfectly from its instincts and conditioning, he does not plot or plan.

The morning we finished plowing for oats dawned frosty. I went to catch the oxen, up grazing in a high, expansive pasture. We plowed steadily as the day warmed and three hawks circled to the east. I walked further ahead of the team than normal, marking their steps as we followed the furrow. I stopped them regularly along the furrow before difficult situations developed. I cultivated relaxation. When the task was over, I walked the oxen back into the pasture and unyoked. Beginning with Burt, I slipped the bow pin out of the bow and put it in my mouth. I hung the washer on his horn and slid the bow out of the yoke, saying, "Burt, back." As he bent his head and stepped back, I slid the bow back in, took the washer from his horn and pushed the pin back in. Then I took off Marvin's bow, this time balancing on one leg to hold the weight of Burt's side of the yoke. I lowered the yoke to the ground and asked Burt to "come here." When they were lined up I slipped my hands under their chins and scratched, holding their heads as they put weight on me. After a moment, I said, "fellas, that's all" and dropped my hands. This ritual keeps them from beginning to graze immediately. This ritual ends the work. + + +

Beam Me Up!

by Matthew Sicher

Simply raising two beams and a post can require a surprising amount of consideration and effort! This is especially true in my house, where the exposed woodwork that we were putting into place is the conceptual and visual axis around which the rest of the house is focused.

I have organized the skeleton of the house around some key ideas that represent the aesthetic balance I am trying to achieve throughout the house. Though three outer walls of the house are modern stick framing (with a unique twist, about which I will write in a future article), the central woodwork is substantial in girth and, well, very heavy.

In my previous article entitled 'The Backbone of a Home", I detailed the creation of our somer beams. These somer beams are resting on a hand hewn vertical post salvaged from an old log home from around the small nearby village of Stoney Run. Resting on top of our beams are green, rough cut Red and Black Oak joists. Finally the exposed sub-flooring to the second floor is kiln dried, tongue and grooved, 3/4 inch pine, with the finished floor for the second floor being old salvaged heart pine from a farmhouse that I remodeled several years ago.

So from the vertical support post to the sub-flooring is a progression of woodwork from quite rough and irregular to very smooth and consistent.



The post from the old log cabin represents the necessary craftsmanship of a homesteading family, clearing the land on which they will live, and creating their home from the materials on hand. Our somer beams are created in modern industrial America; and we are using old style tools and creating old style beams intentionally. The oak joists are rough cut, but clearly cut with industrial machinery. The sub-flooring is the place where we finally introduce the miracle of modern precision cut lumber.

The vertical post, somer beams, and joists are all darker in color; being oak. The pine sub-flooring is lighter in color. This color difference draws the eye, thus further highlighting this woodwork as the center of the house.

I was lucky to have a good sized crew of willing and able hands to put up the beams and joists. The hard working, committed, and inspiring friends and family who were there made it possible to have this fine and beautiful woodwork in our house. It really is a joy to engage in satisfying work with satisfying company!

My father was a great help as always. Also integral to the project were my longtime friend Chris, Patrick (my son's Godfather), and Dan (a fine fellow woodworker and hand tool connoisseur). I was especially grateful for help from my Grandfathers; both my father's father, and mother's father.



My grandfather Robert contributed essential know-how to the project. Robert has built several houses for his family and himself in several locations over the years. Robert always has something to teach about self-reliance and quiet confidence. He has a beautiful house in West Virginia that he built entirely on his own with trees he felled, and lumber he cut from the trees on site. Through quiet example he has been a great inspiration for me, and for this house project as a whole. Hopefully an interview with him will grace these pages in the future...



Plain communities seem to have the right idea with the practice of communal barn raising and the like. Many hands do indeed make for light work.

Sometimes the presence of good company can mean the difference between a project that feels impossible, and one that feels like an exciting challenge. In building a home, as in many other aspects of life, that difference is the difference between joy and drudgery. +++













Bones and Stones continued from page 4 .....

his grandmother. Remarkably these stones carried the four alchemical colors: Red, Yellow, White, and Black (these colors are also the most common colors to be found in early hex signs). Another remarkable aspect of the interview with this particular man is that he named the process of living life according to the principles of Braucherei. He called this way of life "stepping into the hoop". He said that a Braucher had to conduct all of his life from within this circle, and that it should inform everything he or she does, right down to how his or her home is organized, or how he or she conducts daily business.

This man had four stones of four colors. The colors represented the seasons, directions, and elements, just as our contemporary Medizinraad does. He said that the hardest thing about the stones is studying the client and interpreting their energy to decide which stone they need. Once that decision was made, he said there is nothing to it, just hand the person the stone and let it do its work.

Here we see how stones can be applied to give energy that is not connected to the practitioner at all: the stones seem to have a power of their own. Usually stones like these are passed as an heirloom from one generation of Brauchers to the next. These stones would balance negative energies not by drawing out the negative, but by infusing the individual with the energy he or she lacked, thus creating equilibrium between the four elemental energies in the body.

In a very similar example, the Oley Freindschaft (Oley Braucherei Lineage) has some "organ stones" for specific uses. The stones we have were gifted to us by my mentor Dennis, along with the oral history that they had come from various practitioners of the Freindschaft (though we have no specifics like names and dates). There is a wide array of beautifully colored and shaped stones that he handed me in our last training session, just before he passed on the powwow. Dennis explained that the stones were used for the healing of particular organs. Each stone remarkably mimics the shape and/or color of the organ it affects either in reality or symbolism.

In the picture I've included, you can make out several of our stones quite easily. The heart stone is the most obvious to behold. It is small, and dark red with lighter colored veins crisscrossing it in all directions. There is a kidney stone, dark gray in color and shaped like a kidney. There is a brain stone, grayish green in color and roughly brain-shaped. The fourth stone is a liver stone, which resembles the liver only in its symbolic color (it is mottled yellow, yellow being the color of the choleric humor), and not in form at all.

These stones were all used in healing the parts of the body they are associated with. After spending time in prayer and meditation with them, it is my belief that they were used to infuse the organ with healing energy, thus bringing about balance. I do not think these were stones used to draw illness (if they had been, they would probably have been returned to the earth by now). These stones would have been placed on the body and held close to their specific organ for a certain amount of time. This seems very similar to the stones used by the aforementioned practitioner. The Oley stones, however, have one more interesting piece of the puzzle: the organs they represent are also organs related to the four humors of the body: heart = sanguine (blood, air, east, spring); liver = choleric (yellow bile, fire, south, summer); kidney = phlegmatic (phlegm, water, west, autumn); and brain = melancholic (black bile, earth, north, winter). This direct association to the four humors of medieval european medical theory only further reinforces the importance and relevance of



Pictured above are the bones and stones passed down through the Oley Freindschaft to the current day Kutzteschteddel Raad (Kutztown circle of Brauchers)

this system of medicine to contemporary Deitsch folk medicine.

In addition to the use of stones in healing, whether generically or specifically, other minerals were used as well, particularly in the hope to break hexes. The two minerals that were particularly important were iron and salt. Both of these minerals were put to use for their ability to absorb hexes into themselves and thus away from the individual who is using them.

Iron was often worn for this purpose, and was often found at the center of a hex-breaking sympathy. In this case Iron is used for its magnetic properties: it sucks the hex to it and holds it fast so that it can be cast away without fear of return. It was often used as the center of an amulet worn for protection, or in “witch bottles” that were placed around a home to “catch” hexes as they approach. In other cases, Iron was just carried on the person. In this case it often took the form of church nails and keys, both of which were thought to hold other sympathetic properties for hex breaking.

Salt, in contrast to Iron’s use in magnetizing, was used to neutralize negative energies and hexes. Why is this? What is its sympathetic similarity? I can think of several: salt can put out a grease fire, neutralizing fire where water (its usual opposite) would make it more dangerous; salt is used in the preservation of foods, arresting the natural decomposition of natural substances, and creating an environment in which pathogens cannot survive; the ocean is salt water and is the ultimate source of life, mother to us all.

As a neutralizer of hexes and negativity, salt could be sprinkled around a home to create a neutralizing barrier to incoming hexes and negative emotion. Salt water baths could be used in a purification ritual for one who was afflicted with hexes or plagued by negative energies (though I prefer to use this as part of a seasonal or lunar cycle ritual). It the case of baths, even more effective is submersion in the ocean (in a private place where such a ritual would feel safe), but whether the bath is in the home or in the ocean, this type of bath would require complete submersion. Salt water can also be used to cleanse ritual objects such as stones, knives, bowls, etc when they have been used in breaking a hex or in some other healing ceremony.

Often the most effective type of cleansing is the combination in some way of fire and water. These opposites are mentioned in many Braucherei prayers and ultimately represent polar opposite forces: masculine and feminine. To use them both in cleansing makes the ritual complete. The combination could come in many forms: a sweat lodge is one that combines both together (as in our willow lodge tradition); there is also the practice of smudging with the smoke of various herbs, which could either precede or follow a salt water bath; in the case of objects, such as knives or stones, they were often cleansed first in salt water and then in the flame of a church candle.

Other minerals and precious metals have also been used by some Brauchers historically. The ritual usage of such minerals, however, would certainly have been in line with traditional european ritual magical usage of such substances, so I do not feel the need to explain it very thoroughly here. Suffice to say that each precious metal held an association with a planet, and thus held astrological significance, which could be put to use in various ways in healing and sympathies. Most gemstones also have these types of associations and thus their sympathetic usage.

The other gift we received through the Oley lineage was the bones. The bones we received were the bones of a deer, a bison, and a fish (a large one!). In addition to these bones, Dennis gifted me personally with the claw of a bear from a sacred hunt he conducted years ago. For a long time I wondered about the use of the bones, and found no answers to my questions. It was not until last year, when I had a student by the name of Orva Gail Clubb, that I became aware of their origin and usage.

Orva was raised very traditionally in a non-traditional setting. Orva was raised primarily by her grandparents on their farm in western Maryland. Her grandparents were Deitsch and spoke Deitsch in the home. They kept to the folk ways in farming, food, holidays, and healing. Several of her kin were Brauchers of one sort or another, and used these talents along with an understanding of the moons and seasons, herbal medicines, and the nature of various animals (both wild and tame) to create a farmstead and home in balance and harmony with its surroundings. Orva's people had an intimate knowledge of the land where they lived, and held this knowledge dear.

When I told Orva of the bones we had received, she told me that she believed them to be part of a set of divination bones (though the set was incomplete, most sets having a total of twelve bones). These bones, she said, would have been used to divine everything from the weather in the coming harvest to the outcome of an illness or the location of a lost child.

In growing up, Orva was a favored by Grandfather, and when she was small was invited to sit with men during social gatherings when the women were in the kitchen cooking, cleaning, and gossiping away. This took place about 55 or so years ago and times were different then. In Orva's world relationships to grandparents

and family had guidelines. Children in her family were almost never allowed to be with the men, when they were it was only if they were invited and only when they were "seen and not heard". Orva was given this privilege only because she was favored by her grandfather, who held some authority within the circle of men. It was a rarity for her to have witnessed these practices, and she holds the memory dear.

Orva said she would bring herself to where the men were all gathered, and sit quietly and patiently on her best behavior so that she could have a peek into their world. Orva witnessed countless times the bones being cast for all sorts of reasons (she said these men were very adept at using the bones, and would almost "play" at the bones, the way others might when handling tarot cards or dice), and she was able to clearly remember a few particulars to share with us so we could uncover the probable use of our own bones.

Orva said there was always a set of twelve bones, one for each of the months of the year, and corresponding to the animal associated with that moon. Interestingly, the bones we have do not correspond with our moon wheel (with the exception of the bear claw), but *did* correspond with the moon wheel that Orva's family used. She remembered they had a deer, a bison, and a fish. They also had several of the animal moons that are present in our moon (but that we do not have bones for) and several other animals that are different (though often similar in nature, such as the coyote and the fox). She said the bones most commonly used were knuckle bones.

The bones had to be taken from an animal that was either hunted in a sacred way or one that was found dead already (one that "came" to the Braucher). The bones that were taken could not be cooked, but had to be removed raw. After this the bones would be smoked, to preserve them. The carcass would be cooked down to render the fat and the fat of the animal would be used to polish its own knuckle bone. This grease also served to protect the bone from water and decay, helping to preserve it, but why should the bone be kept raw and not cooked? In my opinion, it was in order to keep the spirit of the animal alive and present in the process of divination. In this way, the animal spirit served as a messenger between the spirit world and the world of the living. I also wonder if there were particular woods that were commonly used in the smoking process, thus adding the symbolic energies of the wood to the bones as well (I would think that elder or willow might be especially good for this).

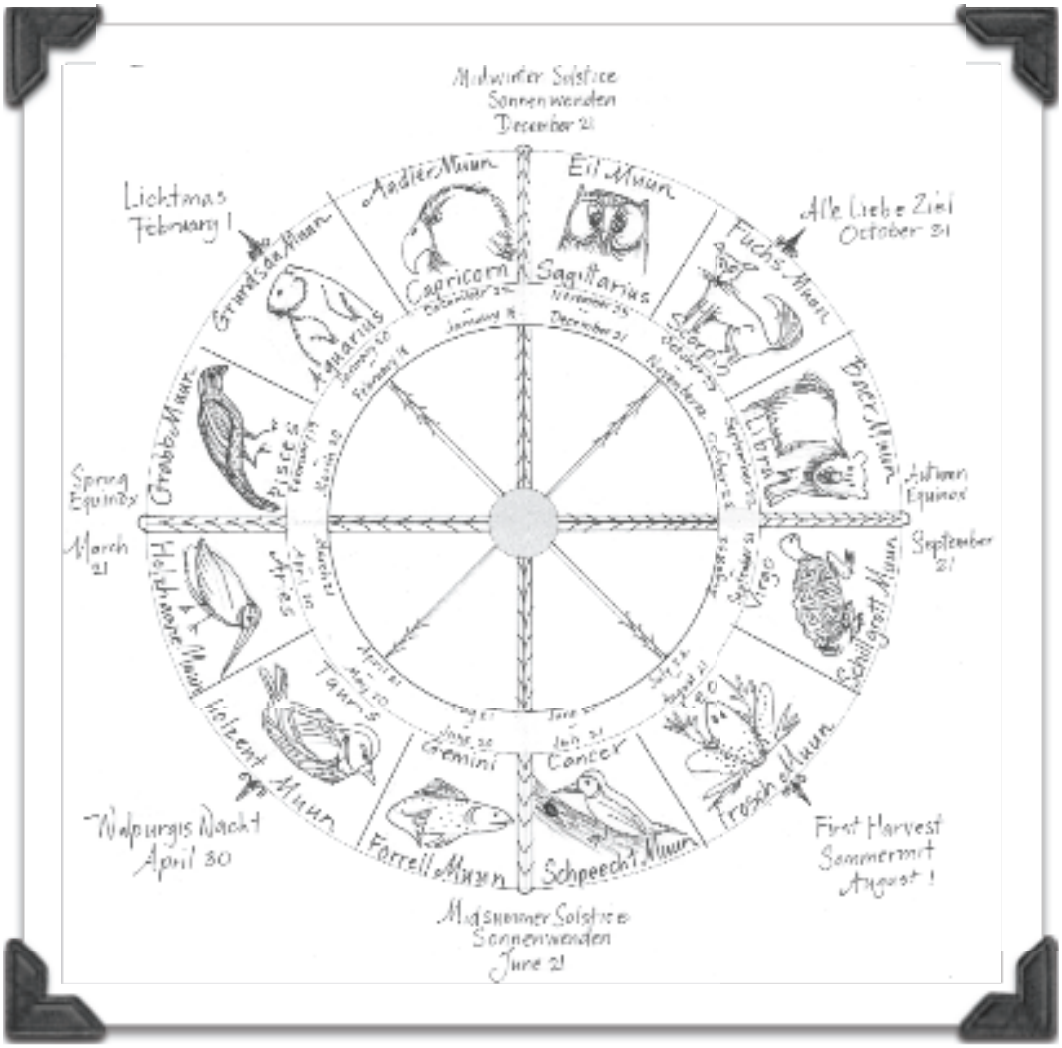
The twelve bones were kept safe in a bag together. When used, they were always cast in groups of three. For a simple question, or one for which a quick answer is needed, a Braucher might only cast three or six of the bones (which would be chosen at random by simply taking the first ones from the bag that the hand would touch). For more complicated questions, questions for which time was not pressing, when an incorrect or incomplete answer could not be risked, or when a group of Brauchers were present to fully digest the meaning of the bones, all twelve bones could be used.

The bones were cast on the image of a medicine wheel (an equal armed cross within a circle). This was sometimes drawn, but often simply imagined according to the cardinal directions of the location. When the bones were cast with the asking of a question, many things were taken into consideration: What position does each bone hold (upright, on the side, upside down, etc)? How do the bones lie in relation to each other and what does that say (what is the relationship in nature between these two animals: for instance, an eagle bone atop a fish bone might bring into the picture the concepts of the predator and prey)? Where is each bone in relation to its "native" place on the medicine wheel (if a "summer" animal like frog lies within the "winter" quadrant of north, it could imply trouble, whereas it

might imply ease and comfort if it is found in its "native" summer quadrant)? If a bone was closer to the center of the wheel, it might be more central to the reading, its implications intensified in contrast to the bones that lie on the outside of the wheel, which might have little or no influence on the problem at hand. And of course, you have the traditional meanings of each animal in and of itself, as well as the meaning of its astrology: the crow can represent death and resurrection (physical death in extreme circumstances, but in most cases only showing dramatic change in life: the death of one aspect or way of life in preparation for another); the groundhog can represent an aloof compassionate nature, as well as an aspect of Deitsch cultural identity; the owl can represent wisdom and the ability to see through the darkness to the truth; the fox represents the trickster, extreme resourcefulness, shapeshifting and invisibility; etc.

The reading of the bones is something that takes decades to master, and even then is often more effective when done

Pictured below is a fraktur rendition of the Yaahrraad of the Oley Freindschaft. Original artwork by Susan Hess, reprinted here with permission.



in a circle of practitioners. More perspectives allows for more complete answers!

Orva suggested that in my pursuit of such mastery I begin with the bones I have and build the set of twelve I need. She said that I should start to practice with the bones daily and in this way work to develop a deeper and more intuitive understanding of them. There are several problems posed by the hope to practice with the bones in contemporary times. The first is quite simple: some of the animals on our moon wheel are endangered, and thus it is illegal and immoral to kill them for the use of their bones. Also, even if a carcass is found without the actual hunt, or act of killing an animal, it is illegal even to possess any body parts of certain animals, such as raptors like eagles and owls. There is also the issue of safety in the use of animal bones that are kept raw, as some diseases can be transferred through this use (particularly in the case of scavengers like the crow or fox).

I believe that there are solutions to all of these problems: perhaps substitutions can be made in a way that is harmonious to the energy of the animal in question? Perhaps through the use of salt and smoking in preserving and drying the bones and the use of gloves in the butchering of the animal, potential disease threats could be avoided.

I have heard of one other type of bone divination in the Berks county region: goose bone divination. Apparently there was a man in Longswamp township who went by the name of the goose bone man. This man used goose bones exclusively for the weather divinations he conducted. Perhaps this example could be used as a piece of the reconstruction process in traditional Braucherei divination. If nothing else, it warrants more research and reflection. As always with this work the mantra must be: *practice and reflect, Iwwing macht der Meeschter!* + + +

Continued from page 6 .....

with three positions across, for past present and future forming the horizontal series, and the upper vertical arm being assigned to assistance, and the lower vertical arm to factors which must be accepted. These two positions are oriented in this fashion to show the grounding force of acceptance, and the elevating force of help and assistance. The first rune to turn face-up should be the central rune in the cross, showing the present circumstance. This should be followed by the left arm of the cross, indicating the past or how the present came to be. The right arm, indicating the future possibilities should be turned third. The fourth rune to turn is the bottom arm of the cross, indicating what must be accepted about the present circumstance, followed by the upper arm, which describes the forms of assistance you may receive. This arrangement is slightly more advanced than the methods previously examined in this series. It is essential to remember when engaging in any form of divination that working within a symbolic framework allows you to more closely examine the contents of your internal processes. The process must be understood as suggestive, relative and intuitive, rather than linear and concrete. As you work with runic symbols and absorb their meanings and contents, you will gradually possess a series of tools which will enhance your ability to relate your life to cosmic principles. Imagination is essential in this process, as the runes will help you to discover hidden potentialities within every aspect of your experience. + + +

Fenchel

Fennel

Foeniculum vulgare

By Jesse Tobin

Appearance:

Fennel is a member of the *Apiaceae* (formerly *Umbeliferacea*) or carrot family. It is an herbaceous plant 4-7 feet in height, and smells strongly of anise or licorice. The leaves are threadlike and the flowers are yellowish and present themselves in large flat umbels later turning to oblong seeds in keeping with the tendencies of this plant family.

Fennel begins to flower in June with seeds coming to ripeness in August. Fennel is naturalized and somewhat invasive throughout the continental United States. It is native to Europe, and there are many different varieties of it, including annual, biennial, and perennial varieties. Particular types of fennel are cultivated for various uses: food, medicine, ornamental, and spice.

Culinary Uses:

In PA Deitsch cuisine fennel bulb is either poached or sauteed and eaten as a vegetable. Its consistency is very much like celery but it retains its anise flavor. The seeds and flowers of fennel can be ground and mixed with sugar for almost any confection. The seeds are also sometimes coated in a hard candy and chewed for a wonderful flavor and to dispel bad breath. Some Deitsch folk would also cook fennel seeds and flowers into bread to give it flavor and aid in its digestion.

Medicinal Uses:

Fennel is a wonderful medicinal herb with very diverse uses. In the context of four humors medicine it is considered to be hot and dry in the third degree. To modern herbalists, however, it is considered cool and moist in its effects. This may be due to what is called the law of opposites: Fennel itself has a hot and dry nature, which forces the body to respond in a cooling and moistening way.

The primary medicinal part of fennel are its seeds. All aspects of the plant could be used in similar ways, but the seeds contain the highest concentration of volatile oils.

The most well known medicinal application of fennel is digestive. Fennel is excellent for dispelling gas both in the upper and lower digestion. Fennel is helpful even as a part of a formula in easing acid reflux. Fennel is also wonderful for even the most extreme cases of flatulence, helping both with the





pain caused by the gas and with the resolution of the gas itself. For colic in children fennel is a choice remedy, for not only is it extremely helpful with the pain of colic, but it is good tasting as well, and easy for children to take.

Fennel is a very helpful as a moistening expectorant, and can be used when a cough has become dry and hacking. In this case it moistens the lungs, loosening the dry sticky phlegm and creating a more productive cough. It is also helpful in soothing a sore throat or hoarseness that comes in combination with such a cough.

Fennel is quite a strong galactagouge, increasing the volume of milk produced in nursing mothers. This is a very helpful herb for mothers who find their milk production to be lacking. Fennel passes through the milk to the baby and can help in this way with colic even before a child is eating solid foods.

Among Deitsch folk, fennel was often used for a variety of eye problems. infections of the eyes and eyelashes were treated with a warm compress soaked in a fennel decoction. Drops made from distilled fennel water were put in the eyes both for acute infection or inflammation and also to ward off cataracts and preserve the eyesight.

Fennel is a diuretic and can have some benefit when used with stronger herbs in resolving a urinary tract infection.

Preparation:

The easiest preparation of fennel is as a tea or decoction. One teaspoon of dried seeds should be combined with 1 cup of boiling water and allowed to steep for at least one half hour covered. As a decoction this same amount of seeds would be combined with one and a half cups of water and simmered for 10 minutes covered. Fennel can also be taken as a tincture or glycerite, though this is often more costly. + + +

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Tis the Season by Jesse Tobin

Sayings reprinted from "Beliefs and Superstitions of the Pennsylvania Germans" by Edwin Miller Fogel, PhD

Christmas and the New Year are nearly upon us. In traditional Deitsch culture this is a special time of year. The twelve days between Christmas and the Epiphany are particularly auspicious in determining the nature of the coming year. Many believe that acts committed (or not committed) during "the twelve days" might portend an outcome or tendency for the entire coming year. This was historically a time of divination for weather, the coming growing year, etc. It is clear that underlying many of these traditional sayings and beliefs are vestiges of ancient germanic belief and custom.

"Grischtdaagoweds zwische elfe un zwelfe muss mer in der Kiehschtall geh, wammer's Vieh heere will schwetze"

If one wants to hear the animals speak he must go into the barn between eleven and twelve on Christmas night.

"Uff Neiyaahrmarye soll mer'n Brotwarscht esse, so ass mer's Yaahr schtarrick un grefdich iss."

One should eat a bratwurst on New Year's morning so that he will be strong and robust all year.

This was most likely originating in the practice of eating pork on New Year's day, which evolved out of the ancient Germanic New Year's day feast in honor of the God Frey.

"Oweds vor Grischtdaag soll mer drei Sadde Esse naus uff's Fenschder schtelle, un der naegscht Marye esst mer sell Maul voll vun yedre Satt. Wammer des dutt, grickt mer sell Yaahr ken Fiewer."

On Christmas Eve one should place three sorts of food on the windowsill outside. On Christmas morning one should eat one mouthful of each sort of food. He who does this will not have a fever for the entire year that follows.

This belief could have evolved from a belief that the spirits of the dead as well as the dieties Woden and Holle were at large during the time between Christmas and

New Year. By offering food and then eating the remainder one might also receive a blessing from these spirits.

"Zwische Grischtdaag un Neiyaahr darf mer net schpinne, un die Schpule misse leer ghaschpelt sei var Grischtdaag, wann's Sach gut warre soll."

If homespun is to wear well, no spinning may be done between Christmas and New Year, and the spools must be empty before Christmas.

In Ancient times the twelve days were especially sacred to Holle (in other regions Frigg, Perchte). Holle was the goddess of hearth, home, unborn children and the spirits of the dead. She was especially associated with the art of spinning. This custom very well may have evolved out of a yearly honoring of Holle.

"De Blumme muss mer Neiyaahr winsche, odder sie bliehe net."

We must wish the flowers a happy New Year or they will not bloom.

How lovely!

"Uff die Grischtdaagnacht soll mer Wasser nausschtelle un was druffgfriert waert waahr."

On Christmas night one should set water outside. The designs formed on the frozen surface the next morning are omens of the future.

The twelve days were a particularly auspicious time for divination, again because of the closeness of the spirit world at this time.

"Uff Grischtdaag soll mer ken Fleesch esse, except vun Fedderveh. Wammer anner Fleesch esst, hot mer ken Glick met em Vieh."

On Christmas Day one should not eat any meat other than poultry. If one eats any other meat, he will have no luck with the cattle that year.

Traditional fare on Christmas Day has always included poultry. In particular, goose was eaten. This is due to the fact that the goose is sacred to the Goddess Holle. The first day of the twelve is particularly sacred to Holle, and in ancient times was celebrated as Mother's night: the day to celebrate the gift that mothers bring the world. Thus goose was eaten in honor of the Mother Goddess, Holle. Pork is to be eaten at the end of the twelve days to celebrate the masculine aspect of the holiday, and in honor of Frey, God of fertility. In some places the feast of New Year's was a feast of horse meat, which honored the God Woden. However, since conversion to Christianity, and the Catholic ban on the eating of horse meat (which occurred in the middle ages), pork has been eaten instead.

+ + +

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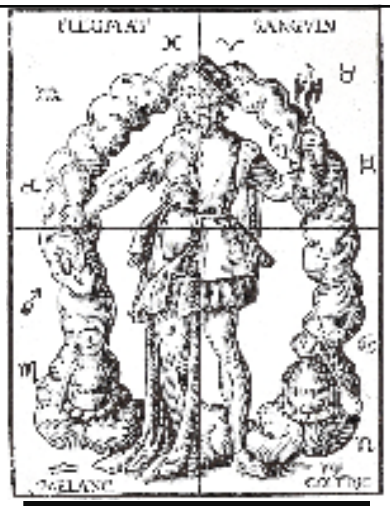
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